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From the editor-in-chief

On May 16 last year when the election results were released, if not a cheer at least there was a collective sigh of relief from many across the nation. That the UPA II had got a clearer mandate than the UPA I. The pesky Left was off the Congress' back and there were only five major allies to deal with who, unlike the Left, would be part of the Government. Great expectations were raised that the UPA II could carry out all the reforms they were unable to do in UPA I because of their dependence on the Left parties. It was believed that Prime Minister Manmohan Singh would be reborn into his earlier avatar of the Great Reformer.

Alas, good intentions don't bring the bread home. In the first year of the UPA II, there have been many lofty announcements but little achievement on the ground. Plus, there seem to be many internal differences on major policy issues like the Naxalite threat, climate change, investment by Chinese companies in India, talks with Pakistan and closer ties with the US. It has taken the Government two attempts to introduce the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Bill.

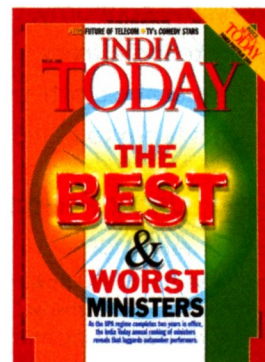
The UPA II's electoral slogan of 'inclusive growth' was translated into huge social sector allocations but these have failed to lead to meaningful reforms in governance on the ground. Progress in infrastructure has been minimal; bills like those on primary education have not been pushed through. Reforms promised in 2005 have not taken off in any sector, be it pension, power, water or even the long-delayed Golden Quadrilateral project. The Food for Security Act has been debated for nine months. There are as many as 16 administrative reforms reports that have to be pushed through and an expenditure committee report has been lying with the Government for a decade.

In fact, there are over 70 bills still stuck in Parliament, ranging from the Women's Reservation Bill, the Communal Violence Bill, the Land Acquisition Bill, Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority Bill, Banking Regulation Bill to the Seeds Bill. Also stalled are a set of pro-market legislations to liberalise pension, banking and insurance sectors.

Of course, coalition politics means that the prime minister does not get to choose all in his team. Some are thrust on him and he is hamstrung in taking punitive action against them. But that doesn't stop him from getting his Congress ministers to perform, specially those holding major ministries. Our cover story this week is a ranking of the ministers of the UPA II by the editors of INDIA TODAY. It is a purely subjective process done by the editors who have been covering the various ministries over the past year. Sadly, although there are a few stars, the overall results are disappointing.

Prime Minister Manmohan Singh as finance minister in 1991 unshackled the Indian economy. Now is the time for him to show what the liberated India can do. Good intentions have to be translated into good performance. Otherwise a unique mandate will be betrayed.

(Aroon Purie)



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2006 COVER